

Image 10.4: Map showing connectivity from Gwadar Port to Kashgar
Source: Archives of AIM Television Pvt. Ltd.

As the forthcoming cold war intensifies, the militancy in Jammu and Kashmir is going to intensify. This is best illustrated by the Pulwama attack on 24 February 2019 and India's retaliatory air strike at the Jaish-e-Mohammed camp at Balakot in Khyber-Pakhtunkhwa on 26 February 2019. That Pakistan carried out a retaliatory but unsuccessful air intrusion the next day, underscores the Pakistani resolve to climb the escalation matrix. It is not rocket science to conclude that this resolve is buttressed by China's presence in the game. Funding the militancy costs the Sino-Pak syndicate a fraction of what it costs India to fight it. It has become a zero-sum game. The Government of India can only continue to ignore the big picture in the background at its peril.